competitive and smart, and has the ability to extract movement out of any pitch. Above all, he's got a great heart. On the night before my first Test, I found a handwritten message of encouragement pushed under the door of my hotel room. It was written by Shaun Pollock, and I still have it today.

Makhaya Ntini also looks pleased with the win. Always so full of energy and enthusiasm, he has given everything yet again, running in hard and taking another five wickets as he helps secure another Test victory. We draw the second Test in Cape Town, but a win at the Wanderers wraps up a solid 2–0 series win.

The next stop is Sri Lanka. Graeme is rested for a tough two-Test tour and we struggle, losing heavily in the first Test and narrowly in the second. The feel-good factor evaporates in the heat.

As the roller-coaster soars, so the roller-coaster dips …

We turn our attention to the ICC Champions Trophy tournament in India. A foot injury keeps me out of our three warm-up wins against Zimbabwe and, although fit again, I am left out of the team that loses our opening match, against New Zealand. I am impatient. I want to play, and am recalled for the second game, against Sri Lanka. We win, and then overcome Pakistan and, suddenly, we're heading for a semifinal.

The venue is Jaipur. The opposition is the West Indies. We bat first and suffer an early collapse, but I play what seems to be an important knock and we reach what appears to be a competitive total, 258 for eight in our 50 overs. But appearances can be deceiving. Chris Gayle strides out to the crease and, in his inimitable way, crashes an unbeaten 133, taking his team to victory with no fewer than six overs to spare.

We're disappointed to see our high hopes of winning an ICC one-day tournament dashed again, but there's never any time to mope, and we fly home for another summer of cricket. India are the visitors and, as we win the ODI series 4–1, I find some form and finally start to feel reasonably established in the Proteas' one-day side. It's taken two years of being